THEN VS NOW

Words That Sell

Classic Copywriting Lessons, Rebuilt for the Internet Age



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WORDS THAT SELL

Classic Copywriting Lessons, Rebuilt for the Internet Age

Seven classic principles of copywriting, quoted from the originals and rebuilt for the internet.

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A Note from the Publisher

Long before anyone wrote a landing page, people were being paid to put words on paper that made strangers reach for their wallets. They wrote sales letters, catalogue pages, newspaper advertisements and circulars. Every word cost money to print and post, so they measured what worked with a ruthlessness that most online marketers never match.

This book goes back to those writers. Each chapter takes one principle, lets a writer from the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries explain it in their own words, and then asks the only question that matters to a marketer today: what does this look like on a screen? Some ideas have survived unchanged. Some have moved to new channels. A few are more important now than they ever were.

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A note on process: this book was assembled with offline software from public domain source material, then reviewed before publication.

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Thank you to the generations of writers, editors and volunteers who kept these works alive long enough for them to reach the public domain — and to everyone who digitised, proofread and preserved them since.

This book is published through GetFreeEbooks, a platform built on a simple idea: that good books should be easy to find, and free to read. Thank you to that community of readers and writers for giving books like this one a place to land.

Quick Start Summary

Each chapter in this book takes one principle from the old masters of selling and advertising, quotes them in their own words, and translates the idea for the internet. Here is the whole book at a glance:

- **Win Attention First** — Write the headline last and test it first: it decides whether anything else you wrote is ever read. *(Still true — but the channel has changed)*
- **Talk About the Reader, Not Yourself** — Every feature needs a 'so that…' — say what it does for the reader, in the reader's words. *(Still true — use it as written)*
- **Be Specific** — Replace every vague superlative with one fact the reader could check. *(Still true — use it as written)*
- **Write the Way You Would Talk** — Read your copy aloud; if you would not say it to a customer across a counter, rewrite it. *(Still true — but the channel has changed)*
- **Offer Proof** — Put genuine proof next to every claim that matters — and never manufacture it. *(More important now than it was then)*
- **Ask for the Action** — One page, one primary action — and make it impossible to miss. *(Still true — but the channel has changed)*
- **Test and Measure** — Change one thing at a time, and wait for enough results before you believe them. *(More important now than it was then)*

Chapter 1: Win Attention First

Every writer on selling agreed on one thing before all others: nothing else in an advertisement, a letter or a sales talk matters until the reader or the buyer stops to pay attention. The opening had one job, whether it was a headline, the first line of a letter or the first words at the door. It had to win that attention. P. T. Barnum set it down in *The Art of Money Getting* (1880):

> *Some men have a peculiar genius for writing a striking advertisement, one that will arrest the attention of the reader at first sight. This fact, of course, gives the advertiser a great advantage.*
>
> *— P. T. Barnum, The Art of Money Getting (1880)*

What It Means Now

Today the headline has multiplied. It is the subject line of an email, the title and thumbnail of a video, the first line of a social post before the 'see more' cut, and the H1 of a landing page. Each one has the same job the display line had in a newspaper: to earn the next few seconds.

What has changed is the pace. A reader scrolling a feed can dismiss an advertisement with a flick of the thumb, and the competition is not the advertisement on the facing page but everything else on the internet. The principle is the same; the margin for error is smaller.

Then	Now
Newspaper display line	Email subject line, post hook, H1
Poster at a crossing	Thumbnail in a feed or search result
Circular's opening sentence	First line above the fold

In Practice: Email subject line

Before: Our March newsletter

After: Why your quotes go unanswered (and the one-line fix)

The first line tells the reader what you sent. The second names a problem they already have, which is the only reason a stranger opens anything.

The Verdict: Still true — but the channel has changed

The principle holds, but it has moved house. Apply it where your readers are now, on screens and in feeds and inboxes, rather than where they were when it was written.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Write the headline last and test it first: it decides whether anything else you wrote is ever read.*

Try This

- Write ten headlines for your next page and pick the one a stranger would stop for
- Make sure the first line of every email could stand alone as a reason to keep reading
- Check what your page shows on a phone before anyone scrolls

Chapter 2: Talk About the Reader, Not Yourself

Early advertising writers learned quickly that readers do not care about the advertiser. They care about themselves — their problems, their comfort, their ambitions. Here is how the anonymous author of *Business Correspondence, Vol. 1* (1911) put it:

> *No other appeal is so direct, so effective, as that which is summed up in the words "you," "your business," "your profits," "your welfare." "It costs you too much to sell crockery, but your selling expense can be cut down by utilizing your space to better advantage;" "Your easiest profits are those you make by saving expense;" "Did you ever figure up the time that is wasted in your mailing department by sealing and stamping one letter at a time?"—these are the letters that will be read through. Keep before the reader his interest. Show him how your proposition would benefit him.*
>
> *— Business Correspondence, Vol. 1 (1911)*

What It Means Now

Modern marketers call this benefit-led copy, customer-centric messaging or 'jobs to be done', but it is the same insight. A common failure on a small business website is still a page that talks about the company: its history, its passion, its team. The visitor arrived with a problem and wants to know whether it will be solved.

The practical test is simple: count the sentences that are about the reader and the sentences that are about you. Online, where the visitor can leave with a single tap, the balance matters even more than it did on paper.

Then	Now
'What it will do for you'	Benefit-led headlines and feature-to-benefit copy
Knowing the customer's wants	Customer interviews, review mining, personas
Addressing the reader directly	'You' copy on landing pages and emails

In Practice: Opening line of an About page

Before: Founded in 1998, Harbour Print is a family business committed to excellence.

After: Need 500 flyers by Friday? Upload your file before noon and they ship the same day.

Count the sentences about the reader in each version. The first has none; the second has nothing else.

The Verdict: Still true — use it as written

Nothing essential has changed here. Move the advice onto a screen and it can be followed almost word for word.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Every feature needs a 'so that…' — say what it does for the reader, in the reader's words.*

Try This

- Rewrite your homepage headline so it names the reader's problem, not your product
- Collect the exact phrases customers use in reviews and support emails
- Replace one 'we' sentence on each page with a 'you' sentence

Chapter 3: Be Specific

The best of the old writers distrusted adjectives. A definite fact, they argued, persuades where a string of superlatives only irritates. In *Business Correspondence, Vol. 1* (1911), the writer (whose name the book does not give) put it like this:

> *One firm has barred all superlative adjectives, not merely to guard against exaggeration but because the superlative degree lacks conviction. The statement that "This is the best collar ever made" is not believed, but to say that it is a "fine" collar or a "good" collar for it is five-ply, and so forth, rings true. It is a better selling talk and so the superlative is not permitted.*
>
> *— Business Correspondence, Vol. 1 (1911)*

What It Means Now

Specificity is one of the most reliable ways to make online copy believable. 'Saves time' is invisible; a concrete, checkable claim about how much time and for whom is not. Case studies, named examples and precise numbers all do the work that the old copywriters assigned to 'facts'.

The modern twist is that specific claims are also accountable claims. Advertising standards and consumer-protection rules in most countries expect you to be able to substantiate what you say, so be specific and be able to prove it.

Then	Now
Facts rather than adjectives	Concrete numbers, named examples, case studies
Exact prices and terms	Transparent pricing pages
Particular testimony	Detailed reviews over star ratings alone

In Practice: Hosting sales page

Before: Lightning-fast hosting with amazing support.

After: Pages load in under a second on a phone, and a person answers support email within four hours, seven days a week.

Every claim in the second version can be checked, so write it only if it is true. That is exactly why readers believe it.

The Verdict: Still true — use it as written

This is one of the principles that has come through the century untouched. The channel is new;

the advice is not.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Replace every vague superlative with one fact the reader could check.*

Try This

- Find three adjectives on your sales page and replace each with a specific fact
- Add one short case study with a real before-and-after
- Make sure every number you publish can be backed up

Chapter 4: Write the Way You Would Talk

The copywriters and business-letter writers of the early twentieth century fought a long war against stiff, showy, formal writing. The copy that sold, they found, sounded like a person talking. Herbert Kaufman described it this way in *The Clock That Had No Hands, and Nineteen Other Essays About Advertising* (1912):

> *Cut out clever phrases if they are inserted to the sacrifice of clear explanations —write copy as you talk. Only be more brief. Publicity is costlier than conversation—ranging in price downward from $10 a line; talk is not cheap but the most expensive commodity in the world.*
>
> *— Herbert Kaufman, The Clock That Had No Hands, and Nineteen Other Essays About Advertising (1912)*

What It Means Now

Email is the direct descendant of the sales letter, and it rewards exactly the same plain, personal voice. The newsletters and founder emails that build loyal audiences read like one person writing to another, not like a corporation issuing a statement.

The same applies to social posts, video scripts and product pages. Plain language is easier to read on a small screen, easier to translate, and more accessible to readers with lower literacy or reading difficulties. Stiffness was a handicap in the age of the typewriter; online, it is often fatal.

Then	Now
The personal sales letter	Email newsletters and founder emails
Simple, everyday words	Plain-language, accessible copy
Avoiding stilted phrases	Brand voice guidelines

In Practice: Order confirmation email

Before: We are pleased to inform you that your order has been dispatched.

After: Your order left our warehouse this morning. Here's the tracking link; it should reach you by Thursday.

Nobody talks like the first sentence. The second is what a shop assistant would say across the counter, plus the one fact the customer wants.

The Verdict: Still true — but the channel has changed

Keep the thinking and update the equipment: the tools of the period have been replaced, but the

reasoning behind them has not.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Read your copy aloud; if you would not say it to a customer across a counter, rewrite it.*

Try This

- Read your latest email aloud and cut every phrase you stumbled over
- Swap one formal sign-off for a plain, human one
- Run your main page through a readability checker and simplify the hardest paragraph

Chapter 5: Offer Proof

A claim, the old writers knew, is only a claim. They leaned on testimonials, guarantees and references to turn a stranger's scepticism into confidence. *Business Correspondence, Vol. 1* (1911), published without an author's name, made the point this way:

> *Second only to the testimony of the man who buys is the guarantee of the seller. Mail-order houses are coming more and more to see the value of the "money-back" privilege. It is the one big factor that has put mail sales on a par with the deal across the counter. Time was when sellers by mail merely hinted at a guarantee somewhere in their letter or circular and trusted that the prospect would overlook it. But it is often the winner of orders now and concerns are emphasizing this faith in their own goods by issuing a guarantee in certificate form and using it as an enclosure.*
>
> *— Business Correspondence, Vol. 1 (1911)*

What It Means Now

Online, proof has become the currency of trust. Reviews, ratings, case studies, logos of clients, guarantees and transparent refund policies all play the role the printed testimonial once did — and buyers now expect to find them before they decide.

It is also more heavily policed. Fake or incentivised reviews, undisclosed endorsements and misleading testimonials are targeted by regulators in many countries. In many places a paid endorsement must now be clearly labelled as paid. The old principle still holds, but only genuine, honestly labelled proof is worth having.

Then	Now
Printed testimonial	Verified reviews and case studies
Money-back guarantee	Clear refund policy near the buy button
Letters of reference	Client logos, press mentions, credentials

In Practice: Testimonial block

Before: Trusted by thousands of happy customers.

After: "I stopped chasing late invoices after the second month." Priya S., bookkeeper, Leeds

A named person, a job and one concrete result beat any headcount. Use real quotes, with permission, or none at all.

The Verdict: More important now than it was then

The stakes have risen since this was written. What was once an edge is now the minimum a reader expects.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Put genuine proof next to every claim that matters — and never manufacture it.*

Try This

- Place one real testimonial beside your main call to action
- State your guarantee or refund policy in one plain sentence
- Ask your three happiest customers for a review this week

Chapter 6: Ask for the Action

The old sellers, at the counter and in the post, understood that interest is worthless unless it becomes an order. The salesman asked plainly for the signature; the mail-order letter came with an order blank, a return envelope and a clear instruction. *Business Correspondence, Vol. 1* (1911), published without an author's name, made the point this way:

> *Time, energy and money are alike wasted in creating desire if you fail to crystallize it in action. Steer your letter away from the hold-over file as dexterously as you steer it away from the waste basket. It is not enough to make your prospect want to order, you must make it easy for him to order by enclosing order blanks, return envelopes, instructions and other "literature" that will strengthen your arguments and whet his desire; and more than that, you must reach a real climax in your letters—tell the prospect what to do and how to do it.*
>
> *— Business Correspondence, Vol. 1 (1911)*

What It Means Now

The coupon has become the button. Every page, email and post needs a single, obvious next step — and a frequent mistake is to offer five of them, so the reader takes none.

Urgency still works, but modern audiences are quick to spot fake deadlines and countdown timers that reset, and consumer-protection rules increasingly treat them as misleading. The honest version of the old 'act now' is a real reason to act: a genuine deadline, limited places, or a clear cost of waiting.

Then	Now
The clip-out coupon	The call-to-action button
'Write today for our free booklet'	Lead magnet and sign-up form
'Act now' deadlines	Genuine launch windows and limited offers

In Practice: End of a service page

Before: Contact us · Follow us · Read our blog · Download our brochure

After: Get my free quote (two minutes, and no phone call unless you ask for one)

Four choices usually end in none being taken. One button, with the reader's worry answered underneath it, gets clicked.

The Verdict: Still true — but the channel has changed

The goal is the same as it ever was; only the route to the customer has changed.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *One page, one primary action — and make it impossible to miss.*

Try This

- Pick the single action each page exists to drive and remove competing buttons
- Rewrite your button text to describe what the reader gets
- Remove any deadline that is not real

Chapter 7: Test and Measure

Mail-order advertisers and sales-letter writers were the first data-driven marketers. They keyed each advertisement and letter so that every reply could be traced, and tried one appeal against another before spending the whole budget. Here is how the anonymous author of *Business Correspondence, Vol. 1* (1911) put it:

> *The time has passed when a full volley is fired before the ammunition is tested and the range found. The capable letter writer tests out his arguments and proves the strength of his talking points without wasting a big appropriation. His letters are tested as accurately as the chemist in his laboratory tests the strength or purity of material that is submitted to him for analysis.*
>
> *— Business Correspondence, Vol. 1 (1911)*

What It Means Now

What they did with codes and ledgers, marketers now do with tracking links, analytics and split tests — faster, cheaper and at far greater scale. It has never been easier to know which headline, offer or email actually worked.

The danger is the opposite of the old one: too much data and too little judgement. Small samples, vanity metrics and tests stopped too early produce confident wrong answers. The old discipline of changing one thing at a time and waiting for enough replies is still the right one.

Then	Now
Keyed addresses in each advertisement	UTM tags and tracking links
Counting coupon returns	Conversion tracking and analytics
Trying two circulars	A/B and split testing

In Practice: Changing a sales page

Before: New headline, new photo and a lower price, all on the same Monday. Sales rise, and nobody knows why.

After: Only the headline changes. Half the email list sees each version, and nothing is decided until each has had a fair number of visits.

The old mail-order men would have recognised the second method at once: one key per advertisement, one variable at a time.

The Verdict: More important now than it was then

If anything, this matters more online than it ever did on paper. The internet has raised both the rewards for getting it right and the penalties for getting it wrong.

> ***Key Takeaway:*** *Change one thing at a time, and wait for enough results before you believe them.*

Try This

- Add tracking parameters to every link in your next campaign
- Choose one headline to A/B test and let it run until the result is clear
- Decide in advance which number will count as success

Conclusion: Old Rules, New Screens

Of the seven principles in this book, two have survived untouched, three still hold but have moved to new channels and two matter more now than they did then. That is a remarkable record for advice written before the first website, the first search engine or the first social feed.

The reason is simple. The media have changed beyond recognition, but the people at the other end of them have not. They are still busy, still sceptical, still looking for something that will make their lives a little better — and still willing to stop for a moment when someone speaks to them clearly, honestly and about the thing they care about.

The writers quoted here learned that lesson one printed page at a time, with every word paid for. You can learn it faster, and test it more cheaply, than any of them could have dreamed. Start with one principle, one page and one change this week. Then come back for the next.

Your Action Plan

Work through one chapter a week. Each list below is small enough to finish in an afternoon, and each item produces something you can measure.

Week 1: Win Attention First

- Write ten headlines for your next page and pick the one a stranger would stop for
- Make sure the first line of every email could stand alone as a reason to keep reading
- Check what your page shows on a phone before anyone scrolls

Week 2: Talk About the Reader, Not Yourself

- Rewrite your homepage headline so it names the reader's problem, not your product
- Collect the exact phrases customers use in reviews and support emails
- Replace one 'we' sentence on each page with a 'you' sentence

Week 3: Be Specific

- Find three adjectives on your sales page and replace each with a specific fact
- Add one short case study with a real before-and-after
- Make sure every number you publish can be backed up

Week 4: Write the Way You Would Talk

- Read your latest email aloud and cut every phrase you stumbled over
- Swap one formal sign-off for a plain, human one
- Run your main page through a readability checker and simplify the hardest paragraph

Week 5: Offer Proof

- Place one real testimonial beside your main call to action
- State your guarantee or refund policy in one plain sentence
- Ask your three happiest customers for a review this week

Week 6: Ask for the Action

- Pick the single action each page exists to drive and remove competing buttons
- Rewrite your button text to describe what the reader gets
- Remove any deadline that is not real

Week 7: Test and Measure

- Add tracking parameters to every link in your next campaign
- Choose one headline to A/B test and let it run until the result is clear
- Decide in advance which number will count as success

Glossary

A/B test — An experiment in which two versions of a page or message are shown to comparable audiences to see which performs better.

Benefit — What a feature does for the customer, stated in terms of the customer's life rather than the product's specification.

Call to action (CTA) — The specific instruction or button that tells the reader what to do next.

Hook — The opening line or visual of a piece of content, designed to stop a reader long enough to engage.

Plain language — Writing that its intended audience can understand the first time they read it.

Sources & Notes

The historical passages quoted in this book are reproduced from public domain editions of the following works. Spelling and punctuation are the original authors'; only the typography (dashes and quotation marks) has been modernised.

- *Business Correspondence, Vol. 1* (1911)
- Herbert Kaufman, *The Clock That Had No Hands, and Nineteen Other Essays About Advertising* (1912)
- P. T. Barnum, *The Art of Money Getting* (1880)

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